and Hungary) and has been used right up to the present day. Nineteenth-century debates about German identity and the future of the nation focused around the issue of securing the resources needed for the economic development of the German Empire. While colonies were considered as an option, many Germans thought that Germany should, above all, build a wider sphere of influence for itself, both economic and political, in its immediate neighbourhood. Although these ideas were also used by extreme nationalists and ultimately degenerated into an excuse for the Nazi conquest of Europe, their origins were more benign. One of the best-known advocates of the creation of a Central Europe as a single economic and political area was Friedrich Naumann, an early twentieth-century, liberal member of the German parliament. Naumann's book with the same title (*Central Europe*[32]) advocated the creation of a loose, above all economic, European federation to include Germany, Austria-Hungary, Poland and countries further afield, from the Vistula river to the Vosges Mountains and from Galicia to Lake Constance, a 'welding together of the German Empire and the Austro-Hungarian Dual Monarchy'. The entity would use German as its main official language, but all the nations would be equal and would have the right to use their own vernaculars. Reading the book, one finds surprising similarities not only to the Eurojargon of the present EU but also to issues discussed today in relation to the European Constitution. For example, Naumann writes that issues of 'creed and nationalities' 'should not be subjected to any centralised regulation… nor will the super-State have anything to do with school affairs'. Similarly, the 'much disputed language question must be left to the decision of the individual States', as should internal administration. He talks about some of the legislation being dealt with by a 'Mid-European Commission', housed in one place, with specialised offices in Frankfurt, Hamburg, Berlin, Vienna and Prague. The 'super-State' would be governed by a 'treaty system as the basis of Mid-European unity' and so on.

Naumann's idea, which some saw as essentially imperialistic, was buried in the ashes of two world wars (although a similar idea of an All-Danube federation resurfaced in the 1930s and 1940s among Eastern European intellectuals). It was, however, resurrected as an all-European idea in the project of the European Communities and later the European Union – two world wars were needed before Europe looked at this idea seriously.